Rafe ("Rachael") Meager

Department of Economics
UNSW Business School (E12)
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Academic Positions

Associate Professor 2023–
University of New South Wales, Department of Economics
Assistant Professor 2017-2023
The London School of Economics, Department of Economics

Education

Ph.D, Economics & Statistics, Massachusetts Institute of Technology 2017
Evidence Aggregation in Development Economics using Bayesian Hierarchical Models
Committee: Esther Duflo, Anna Mikusheva, Abhijit Banerjee, Rob Townsend
B.Comm (Honours), Economics, The University of Melbourne 2011
B.A, History & French, The University of Melbourne 2011

Affiliations

BREAD, Y-RISE, CEPR

Publications and Accepted Papers

An Automatic Finite-Sample Robustness Metric: When Can Dropping a Little Data Change Conclusions? Part I: Definitions and Experiments, Philosophical Transactions A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences, 2026, 384 (2321): 20250001, with Tamara Broderick and Ryan Giordano

An Automatic Finite-Sample Robustness Metric: When Can Dropping a Little Data Change Conclusions? Part II: Theory and Intuition, Accepted, Philosophical Transactions A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences, 2026, 384 (2321): 20240614, with Tamara Broderick and Ryan Giordano

Review of Kardas-Nelson, Mara. We Are Not Able to Live in the Sky: The Seductive Promise of Microfinance. Journal of Economic Literature 63 (4): 1558–60, 2025

Bayesian Impact Evaluation with Informative Priors: An Application to a Colombian Management and Export Improvement Program. Econometrica, Vol. 93, .no 5, September 2025, with David McKenzie and Leonardo Iacovone

Toward a Taxonomy of Trust for Probabilistic Machine Learning, Science: Advances, Volume 9, Issue 7, February 2023, with Tamara Broderick, Andrew Gelman, Anna L. Smith, and Tian Zheng

Aggregating Distributional Treatment Effects: A Bayesian Hierarchical Analysis of the Microcredit Literature The American Economic Review, Vol. 112, Issue 6, June 2022.

Understanding the Average Impact of Microcredit Expansions: A Bayesian Hierarchical Analysis of 7 Randomized Experiments American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, 11(1), 2019, 57-91.

Competing Lending Platforms, Endogenous Reputation, and Fragility in Microcredit Mar-

kets with Peter Bardsley, The European Economic Review, Volume 112, February 2019, Pages 107-126

Fast Robustness Quantification with Variational Bayes (2016 ICML Workshop on Data4Good: Machine Learning in Social Good Applications, New York) with Ryan Giordano, Tamara Broderik, Jonathan Huggins, Michael Jordan

How to Get into a Top 10 Economics PhD Program from Australia, The Australian Economic Review, Volume 47, Issue 4, 2014

R packages

baggr: Bayesian Aggregator with Witold Wiecek
Zaminfluence: Z-estimator approximate maximal influence with Ryan Giordano and Tamara Broderick

Available Working Papers

Implementation Matters: Generalizing Treatment Effects in Education with Noam Angrist

Sensitivity of MCMC-based analyses to small-data removal with Tin D. Nguyen, Ryan Giordano, and Tamara Broderick

Vitamin A Supplements and Child Mortality: Resolving a Controversy in Meta-analysis with Witold Weicek

Selected Research In Progress

A Multifaceted Approach to Poverty Alleviation in Six Countries: A Bayesian Hierarchical Analysis of the Graduation Program with Andrew Gelman, Dean Karlan, Chris Udry, Witold Wiecek

Data Transforms Are Models with Edward Jee

Selected Grants and Awards

UNSW Dean's Research Fellowship (20,000 AUD plus course reduction)	2025-6
AEJ: Applied Best Paper Award	2022
GiveWell Grant joint with Witold Weicek (50,000 GBP)	2022
CEDIL/DIFD Grant joint with Young1ove (250,000 GBP)	2019
Schmidt Future Fund Grant (225,000 USD)	2019
BITSS SSMART Grant (30,000 USD)	2015

Teaching

Statistics for Econometrics, Undergraduate level (UNSW)	2025-
Empirical Methods, Undergraduate level (UNSW)	2024-
Applied Econometrics, Masters and Undergraduate level (LSE)	2018-2023
Econometrics, PhD and Undergraduate level (MIT)	2015-2017
Development Economics (Macroeconomics), PhD level (MIT)	2015
Microeconomics, Undergraduate Level (University of Melbourne)	2009-2010

Professional Activities

Invited Visits, Lectures and Conference Presentations

Australian Treasury Impact Evaluation Unit IEPN Conference, Africa Meeting of the Econometrics Society (Cairo), Bayesian Experimental Workshop Summer School (Casablanca), Macquarie University Statistics Seminar, Monash Econ, LEAP ECR Workshop, ANU Economics Seminar	2026

UNSW Step Up Conference, Harvard Econ & Chicago BFI (both postponed), 2025
UP-SU PhD Workshop (Discussant), UNSW PhD Conference (Discussant/Mentor)

Australasian Workshop on Econometrics and Health Economics (Keynote), 2024
UTS, E61 Internal Seminar, UChicago DIL (Brown Bag),
Stanford (Economics), The World Bank (Applied Micro),
Society for the Improvement of Psych. Science (SIPS) Annual Meeting,
Women in Econometrics Conference Bologna, Brown (Econometrics)

AEA Annual Meeting, Chicago Booth (Marketing Group), 2023
Australasian Aid Conference, CEMFI (visiting),
Africa Meeting of the Econometric Society

UBC, Warwick, UChicago BFI, UNSW, Princeton ESOC, 2022
St Andrews University, IIES Stockholm, University of Melbourne,
Youth Impact Internal Development Seminar (Botswana),
Spanish Health Economics Conference (invited panel)

Chamberlain Seminar, Duke Economics, IIES Stockholm, CEMFI, 2021
The New York Federal Reserve (Micro Group), CREST, JPAL,
Chicago Booth (Econometrics), Minnesota Applied Economics Group

NBER Summer Institute, Yale Economics, Brown Economics, ETH Zurich, 2020
Chicago Booth (Applied Economics), Econometric Society Winter Meeting,
Australian Conference in Economics and Business (Keynote)

NBER-NSF SBIES, Bocconi, IAAE, Alliance/Columbia Summer School, 2019
Berlin DIW, DIFD London, Oxford CSAE Meta-Analysis Workshop,
Paris School of Economics, CIDE, UC-San Diego, ITAM

Northwestern, New York Federal Reserve (Micro Group), EBRD, 2018
Georgetown, World Bank DIME, University of Chicago (Development),
University of Toronto, St Andrews University, Washington University St Louis,
The Econometric Institute Workshop (Erasmus University), NYU,
Oxford GPI Conference, ISBA, Penn State, YRISE Conference

AEA Annual Meeting, Columbia Causal Inference Conference, Cambridge, 2017
Harvard University, MSR New England, Warwick, INSEAD Singapore,
NEUDC Tufts, PSU, Stockholm University, Emory QuanTM, LSE
Monash University, UNSW, University of Sydney, Yale SOM

Editorial Board Service
Psychological Science

Ad-hoc Referee
Quarterly Journal of Economics, Econometrica, American Economic Review, Journal of Political Economy, Review of Economic Studies, Econometrics, American Economic Review: Insights, American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, American Economic Journal: Policy, Oxford Bulletin of Economics and Statistics, Journal of the European Economic Association

Selected popular media coverage and press

	VoxDev Podcast (June 2026), Wall Street Journal (quoted in "Hundreds of Billions in Loans didn't make a Dent in Global Poverty" June 2026), UNSW Business Think ("Maximising Management Consulting: insights from Colombia", 2025), News Guild of New York (quoted in "Racial Disparities in Performance Evaluations at The New York Times" August 2022), Vox.com's Future Perfect (2019), Alice Evans' Podcast (November 2017) which was also featured on IPA's Great Holiday Travel Podcast Playlist
Unprofessional Activities	birdwatching, balcony gardening, interior design, playing Hades (I), bafflingly popular twitter and bluesky accounts, bafflingly semi-popular creative nonfiction newsletter